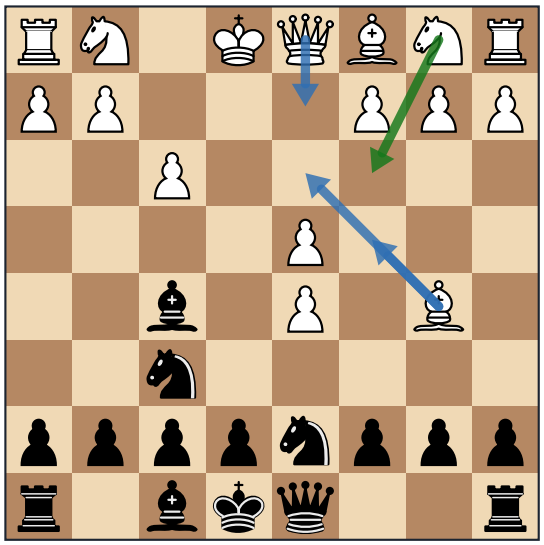
Scandinavian Defense

ECO B01 | 45 named lines | Semi-open / hypermodern defenses

In one sentence: Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Memory pattern: Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.



Main line: 1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 4.f3 Bf5 5.Bb5 Nbd7

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes (Pirc/Modern) or hits e4 at once (Scandinavian, Alekhine).
2. White gets space and often a big center, but it can become a target.
3. Black's key breaks are ...c5, ...e5 and ...f5 at the right moment.
4. Develop quickly and avoid early queen moves unless they win time.
5. White should avoid overextension and keep pieces coordinated.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.74** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best: Nc3.

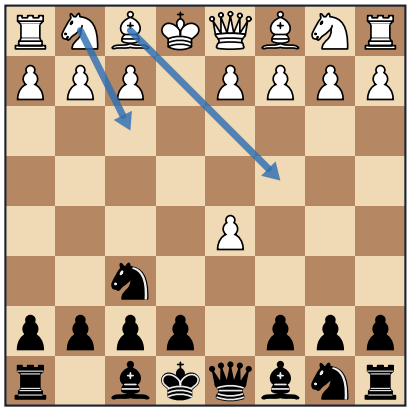
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles short behind the fianchetto; White often attacks with f4/Be3/Qd2/h4.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7, Nf6/Nd7, ...c5/...e5 breaks. White: Nc3, Nf3, Be3, Bc4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 4.f3 Bf5 5.Bb5 Nbd7

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. exd5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
2... Nf6	Hit e4. Develops the knight to f6.
3. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3... Bg4	Develops the bishop to g4.
4. f3	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... Bf5	Repositions the bishop to a more active square.
5. Bb5	Develops the bishop to b5.
5... Nbd7	Develops the knight to d7.



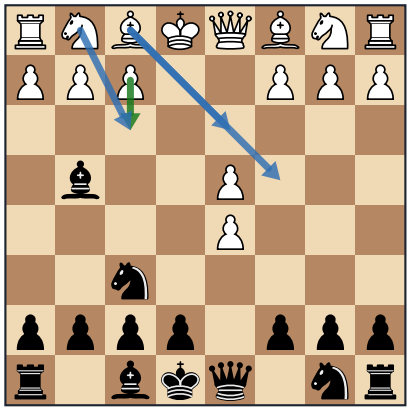
After 1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6



After Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 4.f3 Bf5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.



Position after the line

Portuguese Gambit B01 | 9 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4`

Stockfish: **+0.96** (clearly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: f3.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Banker Variation, Classical Variation, Correspondence Refutation, Elbow Variation



Position after the line

Modern Variation B01 | 4 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+0.79** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Gipslis Variation, Wing Gambit



Position after the line

Anderssen Counterattack B01 | 4 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 e5`

Stockfish: **+1.03** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Collijn Variation, Goteborg System, Orthodox Attack



Position after the line

Main Line B01 | 3 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5`

Stockfish: **+0.84** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Leonhardt Gambit, Mieses Variation

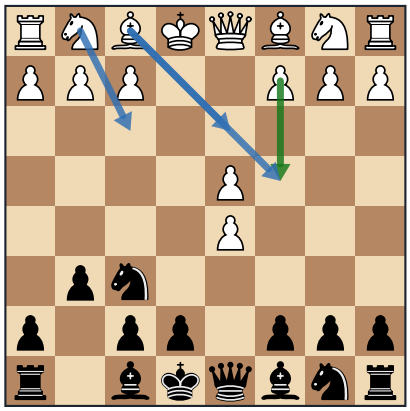


Position after the line

Valencian Variation B01 | 3 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd8`

Stockfish: **+0.75** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Ilundain Variation, Main Line



Position after the line

Richter Variation B01 | 2 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 g6`

Stockfish: **+1.27** (clearly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: c4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)

Detailed repertoire notes

Scandinavian Defense (B01, Black)
`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 c6 6.Bc4 Bf5 7.Bd2 e6 8.Qe2 Bb4 9.O-O-O Nbd7`
Idea: Take the pawn back with the queen and develop quickly; accept an early queen move for solid structure.

Structure: Black has a flexible structure; the queen on a5/d6 is active but exposed to tempo.

Pieces: Bf5 outside the chain, knights f6/d7, Bb4 pin, queen a5/d6.

Plan: Develop, castle, then ...c5 or ...e5 breaks. Avoid wasting time with the queen.

King: Castle kingside after ...Bf5 and ...e6. **Opponent:** Tempo on the queen (Nc3, Bd2) and a lead in development.

Watch out: White gains tempi with Nc3; do not overextend the queen.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Know the move-order tricks: in the Pirc, White's Austrian Attack (f4) is the main danger; in the Scandinavian, learn the queen retreat squares (a5, d6, d8). Always counterattack the center within the first 8-10 moves.

Why play it

Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Typical mistakes

- Letting White roll forward with e5 and f4 without a counter-break.
- Moving the queen repeatedly in the Scandinavian and falling behind in development.
- Fianchettoing without castling early and leaving the king exposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxf7+ or Bxh7+ if Black's king sits behind a fianchetto without defenders.
- e5 forks or pins after Black ignores the center.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Black aims to undermine White's center and reach an equal middlegame with flexible pawn structure.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Scandinavian Defense (all lines)** B01
  1.e4 d5
  - **Zilbermints Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.b4
  - **Blackburne-Kloosterboer Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 c6
  - **Mieses-Kotroc Variation** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5
  - **Modern Variation** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6
    - **Gipslis Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 -> 3.d4 Nxd5 4.Nf3 Bg4
    - **Wing Gambit** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 -> 3.d4 g6 4.c4 b5
  - **Blackburne Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 c6 3.dxc6 Nxc6
  - **Boehnke Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 e5 3.dxe6 Bxe6
  - **Gubinsky-Melts Defense** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd6
  - **Icelandic-Palme Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.c4 e6
  - **Kloosterboer Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 c6 3.dxc6 e5
  - **Main Line** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5
    - **Leonhardt Gambit** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 -> 4.b4
    - **Mieses Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 -> 4.d4 Nf6
  - **Marshall Variation** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Nxd5
  - **Panov Transfer** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.c4 c6
  - **Portuguese Gambit** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4
    - **Classical Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.Nf3
    - **Wuss Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.Be2
    - **Elbow Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.Bb5 c6
    - **Banker Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.f3 Bf5 5.c4
    - **Correspondence Refutation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.f3 Bf5 5.g4
    - **Lusophobe Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.Bb5 Nbd7 5.Be2
    - **Jadoul Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.f3 Bf5 5.Bb5 Nbd7 6.c4
    - **Melbourne Shuffle Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 -> 4.f3 Bf5 5.Bb5 Nbd7 6.Nc3
  - **Richter Variation** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 g6
  - **Valencian Variation** B01
    1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd8
    - **Ilundain Variation** B01
      1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd8 -> 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 c6

- **Main Line** B01
  `1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd8 -> 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 Bg4`
- **Anderssen Counterattack** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 e5`
  - **Goteborg System** B01
    `1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 e5 -> 5.Nf3`
  - **Collijn Variation** B01
    `1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 e5 -> 5.Nf3 Bg4`
  - **Orthodox Attack** B01
    `1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 e5 -> 5.dxe5 Nc6 6.Nf3 Bb4 7.Bd2`
- **Kiel Variation** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Nxd5 4.c4 Nb4`
- **Kádas Gambit** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 c6 4.dxc6 e5`
- **Schiller-Pytel Variation** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd6 4.d4 c6`
  - **Modern Variation** B01
    `1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd6 4.d4 Nf6 5.Bc4 c6 6.Nge2 Bf5 7.Bf4 Qb4`
- **Bronstein Variation** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qd6 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 a6`
- **Classical Variation** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 Bf5`
- **Lasker Variation** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 Bg4 6.h3`
- **Grünfeld Variation** B01
  `1.e4 d5 -> 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 Bf5 6.Ne5 c6 7.g4`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Nf6 3.d4 Bg4 4.f3 Bf5 5.Bb5 Nbd7
```

Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> Nf3 -> d4 -> Bd2 -> Bc4
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> c6

Three rules to remember

1. Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

2. Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.

3. White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

Pawn structure in one line

Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.